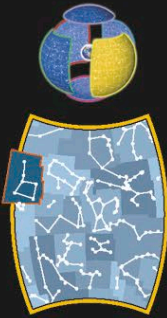


THE CRAB

Cancer



SIZE RANKING 31

BRIGHTEST STAR
Beta (β) 3.5

GENITIVE Cancrī

ABBREVIATION Cnc

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
February–MarchFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–57°S

Cancer is the faintest of the 12 zodiacal constellations, lying in the northern sky between Gemini and Leo, and it represents the crab of Greek mythology (see panel, right). Cancer includes the major open star cluster M44 (see p.290), which is alternatively known as the Beehive Cluster, the Manger Cluster, or Praesepe—which is the Latin for both “hive” and “manger.” It also includes the stars Gamma (γ) and Delta (δ) Cancrī, which represent two donkeys feeding at the manger. These two stars are sometimes known as Asellus Borealis and Asellus Australis, the northern and southern asses.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Iota (ι) Cancrī is a 4th-magnitude yellow giant with a nicely contrasting 7th-magnitude blue-white companion. The companion is just detectable through 10 × 50 binoculars, and it is easy to identify through a small telescope. Another double star that

can be seen through a small telescope is Zeta (ζ) Cancrī. Its components, of 5th and 6th magnitude, form a binary star with an orbital period of more than 1,000 years.

The Beehive Cluster (M44) is a large open cluster at the heart of Cancer, located between Gamma (γ) and Delta (δ) Cancrī. The ancient Greeks could see the cluster as a misty spot with the unaided eye, but in modern urban skies it is unlikely to be visible without binoculars. This cluster consists of a scattering of stars of 6th magnitude and fainter. It appears to cover an area more than three times wider than the diameter of a full moon, and although it can be seen through binoculars, it is too wide to fit in the field of view of most telescopes.

The Beehive Cluster's glory overshadows another open cluster, M67, which is smaller and denser

yet still the width of a full moon in the sky. It lies about 2,600 light-years away—more distant than the Beehive Cluster, which is just under 600 light-years away. M67 can be found with binoculars, but a telescope is needed to resolve individual stars. At an estimated age of around 5 billion years, it is one of the oldest open clusters known—it is also of an age similar to Earth's.

THE BEEHIVE CLUSTER ♄

Also known as the Manger, M44 is an open cluster located between the two asses feeding from the manger, Gamma (γ) (center, top) and Delta (δ) Cancrī (center, bottom).



M67 ♄

Inferior to M44, but still worthy of note, M67 can be found with binoculars in the region of Cancer south of the ecliptic.



MYTHS AND STORIES

A SMALL VICTORY

According to the Greek story, a crab attacked Hercules during his fight with the many-headed Hydra but was crushed underfoot during the struggle. Such a minor role befits this faint constellation.

SCUTTling AWAY

A small crab can be seen in the foreground of this 18th-century engraving, *Hercules Fights the Lernean Hydra*.



HIDDEN CRAB 👁

Cancer is the faintest constellation in the zodiac, but it contains a major star cluster, M44, which is just visible in this photograph as a hazy patch near the center of the constellation.